

NexteraAI Security Academy Module

Module 2: Phishing Prevention , Spot & Stop Attacks Before They Hit

What Phishing Is and Why It's the #1 Threat in SA

Phishing: The #1 Way Hackers Target SA Small Businesses in 2026

Phishing is when criminals trick you (or your staff) into clicking bad links, opening attachments, or sharing info like passwords/OTPs via email, SMS, WhatsApp, or calls. They pretend to be trusted sources (SARS, FNB, Takealot, your supplier) to steal money, data, or lock your systems.

Why It's #1 in South Africa Right Now:

- Phishing makes up **45.7–52%** of all cyber threats in SA (ESET H2 2025 Threat Report) – far higher than the African (32.5%) or global average.
- Over **40%** of South Africans were scammed in 2025, with many losing money (Global Anti-Scam Alliance/State of Scams report).
- SA faces **hundreds of phishing attempts per person yearly**, often via email/SMS spoofing trusted brands.
- Small businesses are easy targets: One click can drain accounts, expose customer data (POPIA fines up to R10M), or shut you down for days/weeks.
- Common in Gauteng/Johannesburg due to high digital activity – scams spike during tax season, holidays, or load-shedding confusion.

Real talk: Most breaches start with phishing. Stop it, and you block 80%+ of attacks.

7 RED FLAGS OF PHISHING EMAILS



URGENT



URGENT LANGUAGE



**SUSPICIOUS
SENDER
ADDRESSES**



GENERIC GREETINGS



**SPELLING /
GRAMMAR
ERRORS**



**SUSPICIOUS
LINKS**



**UNEXPECTED
ATTACHMENTS**



**REQUESTS FOR
SENSITIVE
INFORMATION**



**REQUESTS FOR
SENSITIVE
INFORMATION**

Mitchell-Joseph Insurance Agency
mitchelljoseph.com



PHISHING RED FLAGS

FROM

- **Unrecognisable sender**
Be cautious if the sender's email is unfamiliar or doesn't match the email domain's website address
- **Domain changes**
Watch out for slight variations, letters substituted with numbers or similar-looking characters to create a fake domain that resembles a real one e.g. g00gle.com instead of google.com
- **External sources**
Be wary of emails from someone outside your organisation, especially if it's unrelated to your job responsibilities. Phishers often impersonate colleagues or authority figures to gain trust

TO/CC

- **Unfamiliar recipients**
Be cautious if the email is sent to you and other people you don't know
- **Unusual cc list**
Pay attention to an unusual mix of recipients in the cc field

SUBJECT LINE

- **Mismatched content**
Be wary if the subject line doesn't match the content
- **Unexpected replies**
Exercise caution if the email is a reply to a message that you did not send
- **Urgent exclamations**
Phishers usually create urgency with exclamation marks and urgent language

DATE/TIME

- **Unusual times**
Be cautious if the email is sent at an unusual time e.g. 3am
- **Weekends or Public Holidays**
Exercise caution if you receive unknown emails outside of the business working week

CONTENT

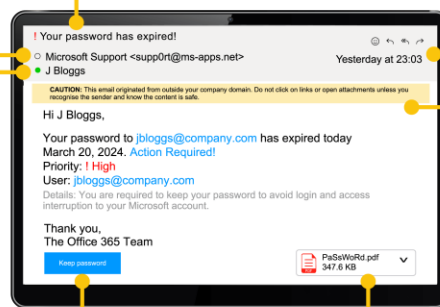
- **Generic greetings**
Watch out for generic phrases like 'Dear Colleague'
- **Spelling and grammar**
Check for obvious mistakes or formatting errors
- **Unusual urgency**
Unexpected emails needing immediate action should be treated with caution

HYPERLINKS

- **Hover over links**
Mouse over without clicking to check if the link matches the displayed text. Be extra cautious on mobile phones, as it is easy to accidentally click on a link
- **URL inconsistencies**
Check for misspellings or slight variations in the URL. Be aware this is sometimes difficult to detect as phishers can use characters from other languages e.g. Cyrillic script (Russian, Bulgarian, etc.); 'a' vs Latin/Roman script 'a'

ATTACHMENTS

- **Unexpected attachments**
Beware unusual attachments that you were not expecting
- **Suspicious file extensions**
Always check the file extension of any attachment and report anything with .exe, .scr, .zip, .docm, .js



Red Flags Checklist

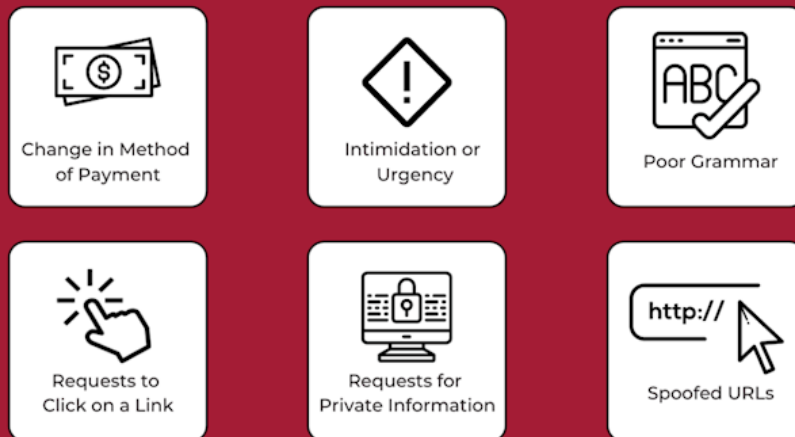
Spot Phishing – Your Red Flags Checklist

Look for these warning signs – if you see 2+, it's likely fake!

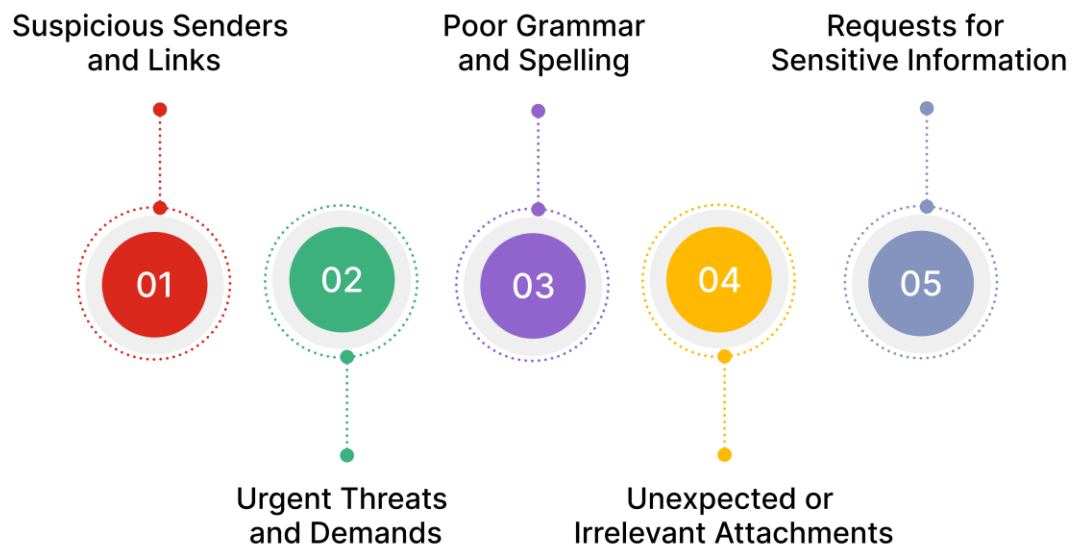
- **Urgent or threatening language** — "Act now or account closes!", "Immediate payment required!", "Your refund expires today!"
- **Suspicious sender** — From unknown/Gmail address (not official like noreply@fnb.co.za), mismatched domain (e.g., fnb-support@fake.com).
- **Bad links** — Hover (don't click!) to see real URL – looks off (e.g., fnb.co-za.com, tinyurl hiding bad site).
- **Unexpected attachments** — Random PDFs/Word docs (e.g., "Invoice.pdf.exe") – never open if unasked.
- **Generic greetings** — "Dear Customer" instead of your name/business.
- **Poor grammar/spelling** — Typos, awkward phrasing (common in rushed scams).
- **Requests for OTPs, passwords, card details** — Legit banks/SARS NEVER ask via email/SMS.

Quick tip: Always verify independently – call official number from your records/website, not the message.

Red Flags to Look For:



5 Red Flags to Identify **Phishing Emails**



Real SA Examples with Explanations

Real SA Phishing Scams – See Them in Action

1. **Fake SARS Refund/Settlement** — Email: "SARS Refund Approved – Claim Now!" or "Settlement Notification – Action Required!" with link/PDF to fake site. **Why dangerous:** Steals bank details/ID. SARS NEVER emails links or asks for banking info (official warning).
2. **Takealot Parcel Notification** — SMS/Email: "Your parcel delayed – update delivery here" with link. **Why dangerous:** Leads to fake login stealing card info or malware install.
3. **Bank OTP Request (FNB/others)** — SMS/Call: "Unusual activity – approve with OTP" or "Confirm transaction." **Why dangerous:** OTP = approval to transfer money. FNB NEVER asks for OTP via unsolicited message.
4. **Fake Invoice/Supplier Bill** — Email from "supplier": "Overdue invoice – pay now" with attachment/link. **Why dangerous:** Business Email Compromise – drains account after fake payment change.

These hit small businesses weekly – one approval = big loss.

6 Practical Steps to Stay Safe

6 Easy Steps to Block Phishing Today

1. **Hover over links** (don't click) – Check real URL matches sender.
2. **Never share OTPs/passwords** — No legit request comes unsolicited.
3. **Verify by calling official number** — Use your saved contact/website, not the message.
4. **Forward suspicious messages** — To your bank's fraud line (e.g., FNB 087 575 9404) or phishing@sars.gov.za.
5. **Use email filters/spam blockers** — Enable in Gmail/Outlook; consider tools for auto-scan.
6. **Run phishing tests** — Free online simulators (e.g., Google/ Microsoft) or staff quizzes monthly.

Bonus: Enable MFA on all accounts – adds huge protection.

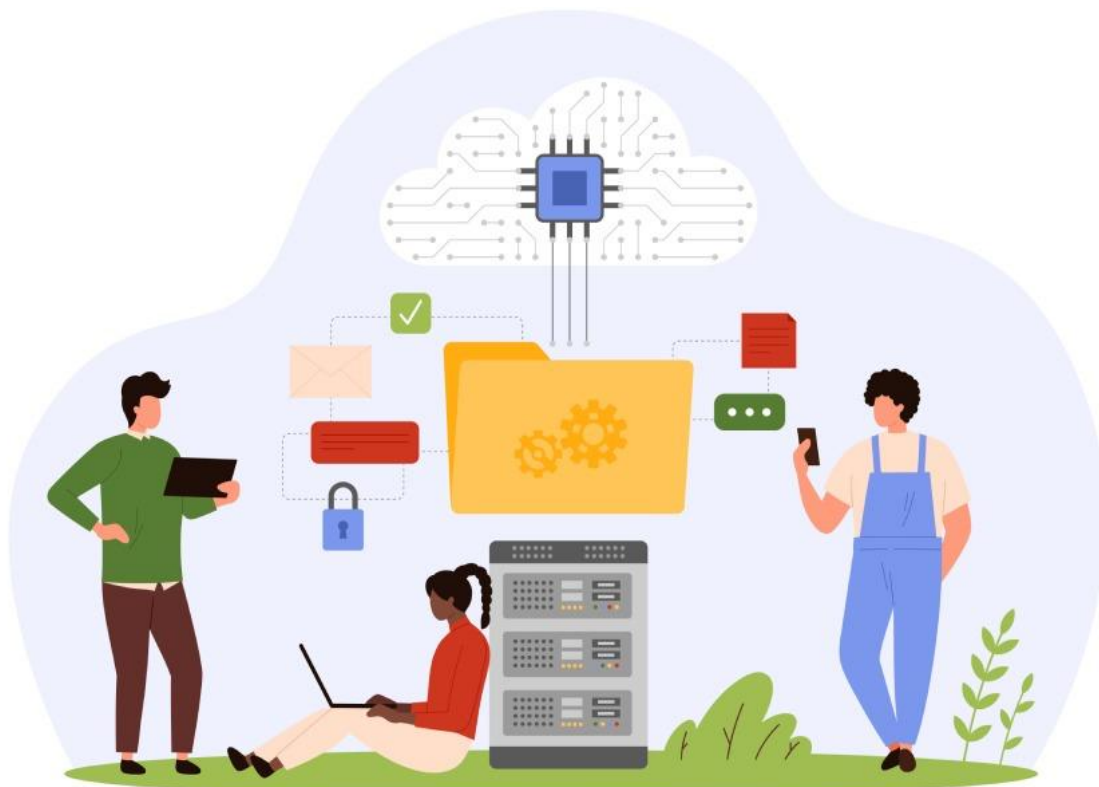
What NexteraAI Email Guard Does Automatically

Let NexteraAI Email Guard Handle Phishing for You

NexteraAI Email Guard is built for SA small businesses – affordable, local support:

- Scans every email/SMS for phishing red flags (fake senders, bad links, urgent tricks).
- Blocks malicious attachments/links before they reach your inbox.
- Flags SARS/FNB/Takealot spoofs using real-time SA threat intel.
- Auto-quarantines suspects + alerts you with "Why this is suspicious."
- POPIA-friendly reporting + easy staff training integration.
- Works with Gmail, Outlook, WhatsApp Business – no IT expert needed.

Focus on your shop/salon – we stop the hooks.





Quick Reference Card (Printable)

Printable Phishing Red Flags Quick Card

Quick Reference Card (Print & Pin Near Computer/Phone):

- Urgent threats? STOP.
- Weird sender/domain? DELETE.
- Hover link – mismatch? DELETE.
- Asking OTP/password? NEVER share.
- Unexpected attachment? DELETE.
- Verify independently – call official!